

Nuno Mendes

PORTUGAL

Age 23

Club - Paris Saint-Germain

Int. caps - 43

Nuno Mendes is set to arrive at the 2026 World Cup as a very different player from the one whose Qatar 2022 campaign was cut short by injury. The Portugal left-back's first World Cup barely got going: he missed the opening win over Ghana, started against Uruguay, then went off before half-time with a thigh injury and was later ruled out of the tournament. Portugal eventually reached the quarterfinal, where it lost to Morocco.

Four years later, Mendes is no longer just a gifted left-back. He has become one of Portugal's most important players in defence and offence, giving Roberto Martinez's side recovery pace, ball-carrying threat and width on the left.

His international stock rose sharply in 2025. Mendes was named UEFA Nations League Player of the Finals after helping Portugal win the title. He scored his first senior international goal in the final against Spain, converted in the shootout, after having assisted in the semifinal win over Germany.

At club level, Mendes has become central to Paris Saint-Germain's post-superstar rebuild under Luis Enrique. PSG won its first Champions League title in 2024-25, beating Inter Milan 5-0 in the final, and Mendes was named in UEFA's Champions League Team of the Season. He also reached 100 Ligue 1 appearances this season, registering seven goals and 15 assists.

